



House of Representatives

General Assembly

File No. 384

February Session, 2026

House Bill No. 5338

House of Representatives, April 2, 2026

The Committee on Energy and Technology reported through REP. STEINBERG of the 136th Dist., Chairperson of the Committee on the part of the House, that the bill ought to pass.

AN ACT CONCERNING THE DESIGNATION OF CERTAIN SERVICE PROVIDERS FOR PURPOSES OF THE FEDERAL LIFELINE SERVICE BENEFITS.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Assembly convened:

1 Section 1. Subsection (a) of section 16-247e of the general statutes is
2 repealed and the following is substituted in lieu thereof (*Effective October*
3 *1, 2026*):

4 (a) [In order to] To ensure the universal availability of affordable,
5 high quality telecommunications services to all residents and businesses
6 throughout the state regardless of income, disability or location, the
7 authority shall (1) periodically investigate and determine, after notice
8 and hearing, local service options, including the definition and
9 components of any basic telecommunications services, necessary to
10 achieve universal service and meet customer needs; and (2) establish
11 lifeline and telecommunications relay service programs funded by all
12 telecommunications [carriers] service providers that provide intrastate
13 telecommunications services, as such terms are defined in 47 USC 153,

14 as amended from time to time, sufficient to provide low-income
 15 households or individuals, or persons who are hard of hearing or speech
 16 impaired, with a level of telecommunications service or package of
 17 telecommunications services that supports participation in the economy
 18 and society of the state. The authority shall apportion the funding for
 19 the lifeline and telecommunications relay service programs among
 20 telecommunications [carriers] service providers on an equitable basis
 21 based on the gross revenues of each telecommunications [carrier]
 22 service provider that are generated in [Connecticut] the state, [both]
 23 whether based on interstate [and] or intrastate services. The lifeline and
 24 telecommunications relay service programs shall be administered by an
 25 entity authorized, and subject to oversight, by the authority. The
 26 authority shall determine by order any telecommunications service
 27 provider eligible to provide benefits pursuant to the lifeline program
 28 and which customers qualify for [the lifeline] benefits pursuant to such
 29 program. Recipients of lifeline funds shall use such funds to pay for
 30 telecommunications services provided by [any] a telecommunications
 31 [carrier] service provider.

This act shall take effect as follows and shall amend the following sections:

Section 1	October 1, 2026	16-247e(a)
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ET *Joint Favorable*

The following Fiscal Impact Statement and Bill Analysis are prepared for the benefit of the members of the General Assembly, solely for purposes of information, summarization and explanation and do not represent the intent of the General Assembly or either chamber thereof for any purpose. In general, fiscal impacts are based upon a variety of informational sources, including the analyst's professional knowledge. Whenever applicable, agency data is consulted as part of the analysis, however final products do not necessarily reflect an assessment from any specific department.

OFA Fiscal Note

State Impact: None

Municipal Impact: None

Explanation

The bill makes various minor and technical changes to the Public Utilities Regulatory Authority's statutes and does not result in a fiscal impact.

The Out Years

State Impact: None

Municipal Impact: None

OLR Bill Analysis**HB 5338*****AN ACT CONCERNING THE DESIGNATION OF CERTAIN SERVICE PROVIDERS FOR PURPOSES OF THE FEDERAL LIFELINE SERVICE BENEFITS.*****SUMMARY**

This bill requires the Public Utilities Regulatory Authority to determine by order any telecommunications service provider eligible to provide service under the state's Lifeline Program (it appears this program is not currently operating).

The bill also makes minor and technical changes. It requires the program to be funded by all telecommunications services providers, rather than all telecommunications carriers. Under federal law, a telecommunications carrier is any provider of telecommunications services, excluding aggregators of telecommunications services (47 U.S.C. § 153).

EFFECTIVE DATE: October 1, 2026

BACKGROUND***Federal Lifeline Program***

Federal law established the federal Lifeline Program in 1985 and also authorizes states to establish state lifeline programs. The federal Lifeline Program provides a discount for telecommunications services for low-income households. The program is funded by telecommunications carrier payments to the federal Universal Service Fund.

COMMITTEE ACTION

Energy and Technology Committee

Joint Favorable

Yea 26 Nay 0 (03/17/2026)